Gilbreth1878

Lillian Moller Gilbreth (1878–1972) · Work design

Lillian Moller Gilbreth was born on 24 May 1878 in Oakland, California, the oldest of nine children, and died on 2 January 1972 in Phoenix, Arizona. She took a B.A. (1900) and an M.A. (1902) in literature at the University of California, Berkeley, where she was the first woman to speak at a commencement, and a PhD in psychology at Brown University in 1915. She married the engineer Frank Gilbreth, worked beside him as an equal partner, and raised twelve children. In 1926 she became the second woman member of the American Society of Mechanical Engineers, in 1935 the first woman professor in an engineering school (Purdue), and in 1966 the first woman to receive the Hoover Medal.

Frederick Taylor's scientific management promised efficiency by timing and standardizing work, yet it treated the worker as a part of the machine. The Gilbreths doubted that Taylor's ideas would be sufficient and saw that they fell short on the human element. Lillian supplied what was missing. In *The Psychology of Management* (1914) she argued that "efficiency is best secured by placing the emphasis on the man, and modifying the equipment, materials and methods to make the most of the man." With Frank she analysed work motion by motion, and she treated fatigue, stress, motivation, and job satisfaction as real variables of productivity, which led her to introduce regular breaks. When Frank died on 14 June 1924, three large clients cancelled. She kept Gilbreth, Inc. running for decades.

Berkeley accepted her thesis in 1912 but refused the doctorate because she had not met the residency requirement; she finished at Brown instead, while raising four young children. Publishers of the joint books with Frank did not always print her name, fearing that a woman author would hurt credibility. For General Electric she interviewed about 4,000 women to design better kitchens; her inventions include refrigerator door shelves and the foot-pedal trash can. Two of her children wrote *Cheaper by the Dozen* (1948), a memoir of the family that was filmed in 1950, and in 1984 the US Postal Service put her on a stamp.

Further reading

American Society of Mechanical Engineers. (n.d.). Lillian Moller Gilbreth. https://www.asme.org/topics-resources/content/lillian-moller-gilbreth

Association for Psychological Science. (n.d.). 'A genius in the art of living': Industrial psychology pioneer Lillian Gilbreth. *APS Observer*. https://www.psychologicalscience.org/publications/observer/obsonline/a-genius-in-the-art-of-living-lillian-moller-gilbreth-industrial-psychology-pioneer.html

Transparency note: This is an AI-generated summary (Claude) that serves as a quick overview sketch. It may contain mistakes; please check important details against the further reading above.